The Tide Festival

Tier	Tier 2
Party Level	**4 PCs at Level 6** — Naan (Lilli), Nalith (Piper), Kto (Kaitlyn), Yinu (Sev)
Duration	~2 hours
Setting	**New Sarshel**, Impiltur — the salt road east of the dark Sarshel Light, the Landward Gate, and the city's Tide Festival. Canon: *FR Campaign Guide* p. 145; *Player's Guide* p. 107
Hook From	**End of Session 007** — the lighthouse is dark, Veyra's ledger is in the party's hands, and the *Embergull* survivors need an escort nine miles east
Tone	Upbeat and heroic, with real villains. The city is warm and the friends are funny; the people behind Veyra are not



Adventure Summary

The heroes who put out the lighthouse walk into **New Sarshel** on the first day of its yearly **Tide Festival** †, and the whole city cheers them through the gate. But Veyra's ledger is exactly as bad as it looked in the lantern room. The people who paid her are the **Gilded Gull Club** †, three nobles of **Gull Row**, whose seaside mansions the retreating sea left a mile from the water. Veyra sold them "**the Summoning**": a demon of the deep to drag the tide home, paid for in coin and in lives the light lured off the salt road. Their leader, **Lord Percival Gullwhistle**, knew the price and paid it anyway.

The session is a bright day at the fair with a villain moving through it. Gullwhistle's hired wreckers try to take the ledger on the road. In the city he plays the gracious host, offers to buy the book, and then quietly threatens the party. At sunset he reads Veyra's last scroll at the Grand Parade. The club's giant clockwork sea serpent wakes with brass teeth, and his clockwork gulls dive for the ledger in the chaos, so that "the lighthouse witch's curse" gets the blame. The party saves the crowd, stops the float, and decides whether Gullwhistle faces the Grand Council or gets away across the harbor. The night ends with fireworks, new homes for the survivors, a harbor light for Tamsin, and a ship ready to take the party anywhere on the Sea of Fallen Stars.

Canon used: New Sarshel is the one Impilturan port that kept pace with the retreating Sea of Fallen Stars and won the region's trade; people from shrinking towns have moved there (*CG* p. 145, *PG* p. 107). **Everything else** — the festival, the Gull Club, the Bracks, the float, Tibbet, the Hall of Many Lights, the freed prisoners' names — is a **DM addition** †.

Tone Rules — for every scene

- **The day is upbeat; the villains are real.** Gullwhistle and the Brack Brothers lie, threaten, and fight to win. Play them straight: no pratfalls, no giving up because it's funny. Combat uses the normal rules, including death saves.
- **The lightness comes from everyone else.** The walkers, Warden Plumm, Brother Amsel, Tibbet, Captain Lorrow, and the games are warm, quirky, and funny. Lean on them between the tense moments.
- **Danger is real but not grim.** Bystanders can be hurt if the party can't reach them, but nobody dies on screen and there is no gore. Telegraph every threat before it lands.
- **Every PC gets a win.** Each scene names a spotlight for a specific PC. Fiorn is not here (Fox has moved to his own game) — do not write him in.
- **The light lied; the festival gives back.** In Session 007 the beam showed each PC a false version of their heart's desire. Today each PC can get a small, *true* piece of it (see Scenes 1.2, 2.1, and 2.2). These are offers, not requirements.
- **Veyra's master stays a mystery.** Gullwhistle only paid her; he doesn't know who she served. See *Threads Left Open*.

The Day's Shape

When	Where	Scene	What happens
Early morning	The salt road, ~6 miles east of the tower	**1.1**	The walk east; the Brack Brothers' roadblock (**Encounter 1**, avoidable)
Late morning	The Landward Gate	**1.2**	Heroes' welcome on **Lantern Eve**, the festival's opening day; beds, supper, harbor lanterns at dusk; **long rest overnight**
Noon, Tide Day	The Hall of Many Lights	**2.1**	The Noon Bells; blessings; a priest reads the ledger
Afternoon	Festival Green	**2.2**	Games; meet the Gulls; Gullwhistle's offer and threat
Sunset	Harbor Way parade route	**3.1**	The Grand Parade; the float wakes (**Encounter 2**)
Nightfall	Harbor plaza	**3.2**	Fireworks, justice, rewards, a ship's offer

Rest. The party has not rested since Session 006 (the DM confirmed it at the start of Session 007). A **short rest** is available on the road before the roadblock (the survivors stop for breakfast). The **long rest** comes on Lantern Eve night in the beds Warden Plumm finds them, so the party starts Tide Day fully rested for the parade.

What's Really Going On (DM only)

- **The Gilded Gull Club** is three nobles from **Gull Row**, the old waterfront street of New Sarshel's first harbor. The sea kept retreating and the city built new docks to follow it — and Gull Row was left a mile inland, its piers standing over dry sand, its families' fortunes going with the trade.
- **Veyra** came to them a year ago. A demon of the deep, she said, could drag the tide back to Gull Row. The price was **400 gp apiece** — and "the light will need feeding" until the tide turned: travellers lured off the salt road.
- **Lord Percival Gullwhistle** understood exactly what that meant and agreed. He told the other two it was "a summoning of the tide," and that the lighthouse was only Veyra's workshop.
- **Lady Marisol Brightwater** believed him. She never asked what the light was for. When she learns about the prisoners she will be horrified.
- **Sir Dunstan Pellow** overheard Veyra say *"the light needs feeding"* and chose not to ask. He is a coward, not a monster, and pressure cracks him.
- **Last night**, Gullwhistle's footman watched the lighthouse from Gull Row with a spyglass and saw the light go out. Gullwhistle knows Veyra failed, and that her papers could put him in front of the Grand Council. Before dawn he hired the **Brack Brothers** to stop anyone coming from the lighthouse and take every book and paper they carry.
- **Veyra left him two things:** a ***Scroll of the Rising Tide*** †, "to be read when the sea returns" (really a scroll that animates a large object), and a short letter in Common: *"The light will need feeding until the tide turns. You agreed the price. — V."* He keeps both in his coat.
- **His fallback plan** for the parade: the heroes ride at the front; he reads the scroll and wakes the club's float; his **clockwork gulls**, which obey his silver gull-whistle, snatch the ledger in the chaos; the city blames "the lighthouse witch's curse." If it all goes wrong, his rowboat waits at the quay steps below the harbor plaza.

Act I — The Road In

Act I, Scene 1.1 — The Salt Road

Purpose / transition: Pick up exactly where Session 007 ended, introduce the survivors as warm, funny company, and put a real obstacle on the road. Whatever happens, the party learns someone in the city wants the ledger badly: *a gent with a golden bird pin and a gull feather in his hat*, who signs himself **"G."**

Setting

- **Location:** The pale coast road across the dry seabed, from the dark Sarshel Light east toward New Sarshel. Session 007 cut as the column set out from the tower; the sun comes up on the road. The roadblock stands about six miles along, in the early morning.
- **See:** A white, cracked salt flat glittering in the sunrise; stranded old ships far off on the salt; behind the party, the lighthouse standing dark at last; ahead, the towers of a city on the horizon. Then, across the road: an old salt-collector's hut with fresh salvage stacked around it, a striped gate pole down across the road, three men waiting, and something big shifting in a washtub of brine.
- **Hear:** Bram's sea shanties, the donkey's complaints, the creak of Dagna's pickle wagon, gulls. At the hut: the click of claws, and a man calling out pleasantly for everyone to stop right there.
- **Smell:** Salt, dust, dill pickles, breakfast smoke; tar and old rope from the salvage.
- **Sense: Insight DC 13** — these men have done this before; the salvage is from wrecks they stripped, and they are counting the party, not the walkers. **Perception DC 13** — a third brother is waiting behind the salt barrels, and the crab in the tub wears a rope harness.

NPCs

The walkers (survivors and freed prisoners)

- **Disposition going in:** Grateful, chatty, and in awe of the party. Roughly fifteen people: **Oren** and the *Embergull* camp (ordinary folk with packs), **Tamsin Reed**, and the four freed prisoners, named here for the first time †:
- **Motivations:** Get to the city safely; thank the heroes; enter Dagna's pickles in the contest.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:** If the party is kind to them on the road, they spread the story everywhere. At the roadblock the walkers pull back 60 ft and huddle around Dagna's wagon. Whatever happens there, **Wren slips off across the salt and runs ahead** to the city — for help if there's a fight, with the news if not (she is fast and cannot keep a secret) — which is why the gate cheers in 1.2. If **Sev says Yinu never grabbed her staff and pack in the lantern room**, Tamsin hands them over now — she brought them down.

The Brack Brothers †

- **Disposition going in:** Confident and businesslike. Salt-road wreckers who strip stranded ships and anyone who crosses the flats alone. **Mort** (lean, black moustache, weighted net, does the talking — polite, and never means it), **Ned** (wiry, squinting, a sling and a bandolier of lead shot; says almost nothing), and **Ollie** (huge and bald, the muscle, devoted to his brothers), plus **Clacker**, their harnessed giant crab, who hauls salvage.
- **Motivations:** A "gent from the city" paid them 25 gp before dawn, with 50 more on delivery: *take every book and paper from the lighthouse folk, and see nobody from the lighthouse reaches the city to tell tales.* They don't know or care why. They take pride in a clean job.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Encounter: Encounter 1 — The Brack Brothers' Roadblock (File 2). Avoidable; Medium.

Conditional follow-through:

If the Bracks were bought off, scared off, or bluffed, or surrendered and were let go: they still want the 50 gp they were promised. They turn up at the Grand Parade to collect it from Gullwhistle, and when the float wakes, Mort decides he wasn't paid enough to watch children get crushed: they **clear one crowd group on round 2** of Encounter 2.

If the Bracks surrendered and the party took them in: the walkers help march them to the gate, and the watch takes them in 1.2. By Tide Day they are in the stocks on Festival Green in 2.2. When Gullwhistle walks past, Mort shouts across the green: *"Oi! G! You owe us fifty!"* — naming their employer in front of everyone.

If the Bracks fled (Ned and Ollie may run if Mort is down and the way is open): they are gone; they play no further part.

If the party handed over the real ledger: the Bracks deliver it to Gullwhistle by noon. Amsel can't read it in 2.1, but the gull purse still leads to the Gulls (he knows whose colors those are), and Marisol's confession in 2.2 is enough to expose the club. The ledger is in Gullwhistle's coat in 3.1, and the gulls have no ledger to chase (they attack PCs instead). If he is captured, it is recovered as evidence in 3.2.

Every branch: the party has seen the **teal-and-gold gull purse**. If the Bracks talked, they also know **"golden bird pin, gull feather in his hat"** and the signature **"G."** That is the thread to Scenes 2.1 and 2.2.

Act I, Scene 1.2 — Heroes at the Gate

Purpose / transition: Pay off the party's good deed with a big, warm welcome, house the survivors, explain the festival, and give everyone the long rest they badly need. The festival schedule becomes the session's map.

Setting

- **Location:** The **Landward Gate** of New Sarshel and the streets just inside. It is **Lantern Eve**, the festival's opening day.
- **See:** A crowd at the gate (Wren in front, jumping up and down); strings of bunting; paper lanterns going up on every balcony; workers hammering stalls on Festival Green; down at the harbor, the new docks crowded with ships. On the far side of the city, the long empty piers of **Gull Row** stand over dry sand.
- **Hear:** Cheering, a brass band warming up badly, a town crier announcing tomorrow's schedule, a fiddle somewhere.
- **Smell:** Fried dough, roasting nuts, sea wind from the new harbor.
- **Sense: History DC 12** or asking anyone — the Tide Festival celebrates the year New Sarshel "caught the sea": when the water drew back, the city built new docks to follow it, and it has prospered ever since. Gull Row was the old harbor, and its families have never forgiven the city for moving on.

NPCs

Warden Bettina Plumm †

- **Disposition going in:** Thrilled. A brisk halfling festival warden with an enormous clipboard, a whistle, and opinions about bunting.
- **Motivations:** Run a perfect festival. Now she has *real heroes* for it.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:** Finds beds for every survivor and the party at **the Salty Pelican** inn, free. Hands the party the festival schedule (*Handout — The Tide Festival Schedule*, File 3) and invites them to ride at the front of tomorrow's Grand Parade. **If shown the ledger, the "G." note, or told about the gull purse**, she goes quiet: "Gold gulls — that's the Gilded Gull Club. And Lord Gullwhistle sits on my festival committee." She can't accuse a lord of Gull Row on a festival day without proof, and asks the party to bring it, ideally before the parade.

Until then: *"Keep that book out of sight. Gull Row has long arms."* **She is the person who can bring in the watch and the Grand Council in 3.2.**

Tamsin Reed

- **Disposition going in:** Warm, tired, glad to be free. She has kept a light for twenty years and does not know what to do with her hands.
- **Motivations:** Make sure the survivors are housed; find a use for herself.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:** Mentions the harbor's own light is badly kept ("a candle in a jar, that one"). Sets up her new job in 3.2.

Encounter: None

Lantern Eve, at dusk (optional, gentle). Everyone floats a paper lantern on the harbor for someone they miss or something they hope for. **Nalith's spotlight:** in Session 007 the light showed her Christmas with her late mother; here she can float a lantern for her mother. Keep it short and sweet, and only if Piper wants it.

Conditional follow-through:

If the party showed Warden Plumm the ledger, the note, or the purse clue: in 2.2 she finds them on Festival Green and points out the three Gulls by name — no searching needed.

If the party mentioned the gull purse or the golden-pin clue to anyone in the city: they hear that "the Gilded Gull Club wears gold gull pins — those Gull Row families."

Long rest overnight at the Salty Pelican. The party starts Tide Day fully restored.

Act II — The Festival

Act II, Scene 2.1 — Bells and Blessings

Purpose / transition: A warm, quiet scene before the noise. The church thread from Session 007 pays off, each PC can get a gentle blessing, and a priest reads the ledger closely enough to name the club and the phrase *"for the Summoning."* That sends the party to the games to find the Gulls.

Setting

- **Location: The Hall of Many Lights** † — New Sarshel's big, friendly temple, with an altar for every god anyone in the city has ever prayed to, and one small unmarked altar *"for the gods we haven't met yet."*
- **See:** Hundreds of candles; stained glass with every color of sea; families in festival clothes; a children's choir lined up and fidgeting.
- **Hear:** The **Noon Bells** — every bell in the city at once — then the choir.
- **Smell:** Beeswax, incense, flowers, festival bread blessed at the door.
- **Sense: Religion DC 10** — the unmarked altar welcomes any god, including ones no priest in the Hall knows by name (useful for Kto's god, Naan's patron Zophiel, or anyone else's).

NPCs

Brother Amsel Tidewell †

- **Disposition going in:** Kind, curious, and a bit nosy. A round, cheerful priest who keeps the unmarked altar and remembers everyone's name.
- **Motivations:** Welcome every visitor; thank the heroes; see justice done for the people the light took.

- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Encounter: None

Conditional follow-through:

If the party tells Amsel about Veyra's demon and the prisoners: he takes it seriously. A demon fed on travellers is not a small thing; the Hall will care for the four freed prisoners, and whoever paid for it *"knew what they were buying, or chose not to know."*

If the party skips the Hall: Brother Amsel finds them on Festival Green in 2.2 handing out blessed bread, and reads the ledger there.

Either way: the party knows **the Gilded Gull Club**, **Gull Row**, and the phrase **"for the Summoning."**

Act II, Scene 2.2 — Festival Games and the Gilded Gulls

Purpose / transition: The fun centre of the session — and the moment the villain shows his face. Every PC gets a game to win while the party meets the Gulls, hears Gullwhistle's offer and his threat, and gathers proof. What the party learns and who they win over here changes the Grand Parade.

Setting

- **Location: Festival Green**, a big lawn by the old seawall, packed with stalls and games, with Gull Row's stranded piers in plain view.
- **See:** An archery range with straw gulls as targets; a sand track for crab races; a pickle-eating stage (Dagna's barrels on it); Tibbet's fireworks cart in a roped-off corner; and the three **Gilded Gulls** in teal-and-gold finery and golden gull pins, holding court under a striped awning. Two brass **clockwork gulls** perch on the awning's poles. Beyond it all, the club's parade float: a giant painted **clockwork sea serpent** being polished for tonight.
- **Hear:** Barkers, cheering, a crab announcer, Bram singing, and Lord Gullwhistle's easy laugh — and now and then a thin silver whistle, at which the clockwork gulls turn their heads.
- **Smell:** Dill, sugar, fried fish, gunpowder near Tibbet's cart.
- **Sense: Detect Magic** — faint transmutation from a scroll in Gullwhistle's coat, and a faint conjuration glimmer from a sea-glass charm on his watch chain. **Arcana DC 13** on the float — it is full of clockwork, but there is nothing magic about it (yet).

The games (pick any; each is a quick roll or two)

- **Kto — the Archery Contest.** Three rounds against the city's best. Ranged attack rolls against AC 15, 17, 19; win two of three to take the Champion's Sash. Kto's +9 longbow is made for this.
- **Nalith — the Crab Races.** Pick a crab (Animal Handling DC 12 to choose a fast one; a druid may simply *ask* the crabs). Win and the crab, **Admiral Snips**, decides it lives with Nalith now.
- **Yinu — Tibbet's Fireworks.** Tibbet's finale rockets are mixed up. Arcana DC 13 (or any clever plan) sorts them. Tibbet teaches Yinu a fireworks trick — **the real lesson the light faked with Elminster** — and gives her a scroll (see *Loot*).
- **Everyone — the Pickle-Eating Contest.** Constitution saves, DC 10, then 12, then 14; last one standing wins Dagna's Golden Gherkin. **No pickled eggs** — a certain hero's religion forbids them.

NPCs

Lord Percival Gullwhistle †

- **Disposition going in:** Gracious, witty, and completely in control. Slim and elegant, silver-streaked ginger beard, teal-and-gold coat, a gull feather in his tricorn, a gold gull pin, a rapier he clearly knows how to use. He greets the party as "the lighthouse heroes," shakes every hand, and remembers every name.
- **Motivations:** Get the ledger and the letter destroyed; keep his name clean; still, somehow, get the sea back to Gull Row.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Lady Marisol Brightwater †

- **Disposition going in:** Polite, a little sad, and nervous around Gullwhistle. She misses swimming off her own pier.
- **Motivations:** The sea back; to not be a bad person.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:** The weak link. **Persuasion DC 12**, a kind word away from Gullwhistle, or ***Charm Person*** (which works fine out of combat) gets her side of it: Veyra promised to "summon the tide home"; they paid 400 gp each; Percival handled everything with Veyra. **Told about the prisoners**, she goes white, then furious, and **switches sides**. She will repeat it to Warden Plumm, and she knows the float's secret: **the big brass wind-key on its back turns it off.**

Sir Dunstan Pellow †

- **Disposition going in:** Blustering; waves a cane; keeps glancing at Gullwhistle.
- **Motivations:** Sail his yacht from his front door again; never be blamed.
- **Possible outcomes and effects: Insight DC 12** — he is frightened, and not of the party. **Intimidation DC 13** (or Persuasion DC 15 with Marisol's confession in hand) cracks him: *"Percival said the light needed feeding! I didn't ask what that meant. I didn't want to know!"* That is the proof that Gullwhistle knew.

Tibbet Sparkwright †

- **Disposition going in:** Delighted by anyone who likes explosions; talks a mile a minute and laughs at her own singed eyebrows.
- **Motivations:** A perfect finale.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:** Overheard Gullwhistle behind her cart this morning, telling his footman: *"The heroes ride at the front. When the serpent wakes, see that the book goes into the harbor with them."* She didn't understand it, and repeats it to anyone who helps with her rockets.

Hettie Quillfeather

- **Disposition going in:** Eager to show off her map.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:** Her map shows Gull Row a mile inland and the Gull Club's piers over dry sand — **the "why"** in one picture.

Exposing the club. The party **exposes** the Gulls if they make the case to Warden Plumm (or the crowd from the pickle stage) with the ledger plus **one** of: Marisol's confession, Dunstan's admission, Veyra's letter, or the Bracks naming "G." in the stocks. Plumm can't arrest a lord without the Grand Council, but she can strip him of his parade place and set the watch on him. There is no wrong way to do it.

Encounter: None

Conditional follow-through:

If the party exposed the club: Gullwhistle slips his watchmen at sunset, climbs onto the float as the parade forms, and reads the scroll openly from its back: *"If the sea won't come for me, it can come for you."* **3.1 happens, and he starts aboard.**

Otherwise: Gullwhistle watches from the grandstand and reads the scroll quietly under the noise of the band, as Tibbet's overheard warning promised. **3.1 happens either way.**

If Marisol switched sides: in 3.1 she shouts the wind-key secret on round 1, and climbing onto the float is automatic for the first PC who tries.

If the party lifted the scroll and letter: the letter is proof (it counts toward exposing the club). Gullwhistle reads a *second* copy of the scroll — Veyra left him two — from the grandstand.

Spotlight wins carry forward: Kto's sash, Admiral Snips, Tibbet's scroll, and the Golden Gherkin all appear in 3.2.

Act III — The Grand Parade

Act III, Scene 3.1 — The Serpent Wakes

Purpose / transition: The big set-piece fight. The float wakes with real teeth, the party saves the crowd and stops it, and Gullwhistle makes his last try for the ledger — or his escape.

Setting

- **Location: Harbor Way**, the parade route, from the top of the street down to the harbor plaza and its big fountain. The party is at the front of the parade (Warden Plumm insisted).
- **See:** Cheering crowds in the grandstands; a pickle stall; a puppet show for little kids by the fountain; confetti cannons on the corners; the **Grand Sea-Serpent Float**, teal and gold, rolling into place behind the party. The two clockwork gulls circle overhead.
- **Hear:** A brass band, cheering, a silver whistle — then a deep grinding of gears, and a hiss of steam from inside the serpent.
- **Smell:** Gunpowder, sugar, sea air, then hot brass and steam.
- **Sense: Perception DC 15** (automatic for anyone watching him because of Tibbet's warning) — Gullwhistle in the grandstand's front row, reading from a scroll that crumbles to glowing ash. **Arcana DC 12** once it wakes — the scroll animated the float; it isn't the sea or a demon, but those brass teeth are real. ***Dispel Magic*** can end it (File 2).

NPCs

Lord Percival Gullwhistle

- **Disposition going in:** Calm and smiling if he's unexposed in the grandstand; coldly furious if he was exposed and is riding the float.
- **Motivations:** Get the ledger (his gulls go for whoever carries it); failing that, escape to his rowboat at the quay.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Encounter: Encounter 2 — The Grand Sea-Serpent Float (File 2). Hard.

Conditional follow-through:

If the Bracks went free in 1.1: they arrive to collect their fifty, see what's happening, and clear one crowd group on round 2.

If Marisol switched sides in 2.2: she shouts the wind-key secret on round 1.

However the float stops (smashed, dispelled, or wound down), it ends in the fountain with a long dying whistle of steam.

Gullwhistle captured, surrendered, or knocked out → justice in 3.2. **Escaped** → he's gone across the harbor; a villain who can return.

Crowd groups saved (0–3) carry into 3.2's cheers and rewards. Groups that scattered were hurt; nobody died, and the Hall's healers see to them overnight.

Act III, Scene 3.2 — Fireworks and Justice

Purpose / transition: The happy ending, earned. The city sees what Gullwhistle did, the survivors get new homes, everyone is rewarded, Tamsin gets a new light, and a ship offers to take the party anywhere — the hook for the next session.

Setting

- **Location:** The harbor plaza, around the fountain, at nightfall.
- **See:** The float in pieces in the fountain; the watch arriving with lanterns; the crowd pressing in; Tibbet's finale rockets lighting the sky over the new harbor; ships' lanterns on the water.
- **Hear:** The biggest cheer of the day, Bram leading the whole plaza in a shanty, fireworks.
- **Smell:** Gunpowder, wet canvas, hot brass, pickle brine, sea.

NPCs

Lord Gullwhistle and the Gilded Gull Club

- **Disposition going in:** Gullwhistle cold and silent (if taken); Marisol ashamed and determined; Dunstan sweating.
- **Motivations:** Gullwhistle — say nothing until the Council. Marisol — make it right. Dunstan — save himself.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Warden Bettina Plumm

- **Disposition going in:** Overjoyed, and a little shaken.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:** Names the party **Heroes of the Tide** in front of the whole city. For each crowd group saved in 3.1, the crowd gives a bigger cheer; **if all three were saved, every PC gains Heroic Inspiration.** She names **Tamsin Reed keeper of the harbor light**, and Tamsin, for the first time all session, looks like she knows exactly what to do with her hands.

Captain Ama Lorrow †

- **Disposition going in:** Impressed and grinning. A cheerful half-orc sea captain of the merchant ship ***Laughing Otter***, who tells terrible jokes and laughs at all of them.
- **Motivations:** Good company on a long voyage, and heroes are good luck.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:** Offers the party **free passage anywhere on the Sea of Fallen Stars**, sailing in three days. **This is the hook for Session 009:** ask the players where they want to go.

Encounter: None

Conditional follow-through:

The *Embergull* survivors and the four freed prisoners settle in New Sarshel: Dagna's pickles win a stall, Hettie gets a job at the harbor office, Bram sings at the Salty Pelican, and Wren starts an apprenticeship at a city bakery (and keeps the party's autographs).

Tamsin keeps the harbor light — a friend in New Sarshel if the party ever comes back.

The ledger goes to the Grand Council as evidence, unless the party wants to keep it (Plumm asks for it if Gullwhistle is on trial).

Session 009: wherever the *Laughing Otter* sails.

Threads Left Open — Do Not Resolve Today

- **Who Veyra really worked for, and why she wanted a demon.** Gullwhistle only paid her and doesn't know who she served. Leave it alone.
- **Gullwhistle, if he escaped** — a villain at large on the Sea of Fallen Stars.
- **Sela's fate, and Oberon** (Session 006).
- **The drow beneath Old Skull and Shadowdale unwarned** (Session 006) — Brother Amsel's letter is the only nudge, and only if the party wants it.
- **Yinu's cipher book** and **Naan's Lathander letter** — untouched.
- **Fiorn** — Fox has moved to his own game; nothing in the fiction explains where Fiorn is. Do not write him in.
- **Tyvlex (Kaila) and Dirk (Ari)** — not at this table.

Loot & Rewards Summary

Reward	From	When
25 gp	Mort's purse (Gullwhistle's down payment)	1.1 — if the Bracks are beaten or surrender
The "G." note (evidence)	Mort's coat	1.1 — if the Bracks are beaten, bought, or scared off
600 gp (150 gp each)	Seized Gull Row estate and Marisol's purse	3.2
Champion's Sash (cosmetic) and **3 × +1 arrows**	Archery Contest	2.2 — Kto, if she wins
Admiral Snips — a crab pet (no stats; very loyal)	Crab Races	2.2 — Nalith, if she wins
Spell scroll of *Pyrotechnics* (*Xanathar's Guide*; Yinu can copy it)	Tibbet Sparkwright	2.2 — Yinu, or whoever helped
Golden Gherkin (cosmetic trophy)	Dagna	2.2 — pickle champion
2 × potion of healing	The Hall of Many Lights	2.1
Gullwhistle's gold gull pin (trophy, 25 gp)	Gullwhistle	3.2 — if he was taken
Heroic Inspiration for every PC	The crowd	3.2 — if all three crowd groups were saved
Free passage on the *Laughing Otter*	Captain Ama Lorrow	3.2

Leveling: sheets should already be rebuilt to Level 6 before play (the milestone was earned in Session 004). No new milestone is required by this session; that is the DM's call.

DM Additions †

The Tide Festival, Lantern Eve and Tide Day; the Gilded Gull Club (Gullwhistle, Brightwater, Pellow) and Gull Row; Veyra's letter; the Brack Brothers and Clacker; Warden Bettina Plumm; the Salty Pelican; the Hall of Many Lights and Brother Amsel Tidewell; Tibbet Sparkwright; the four freed prisoners' names (Bram Tolliver, Hettie Quillfeather, Dagna Stoutbarrel, Wren Ashby); Captain Ama Lorrow and the *Laughing Otter*; the *Scroll of the Rising Tide*, the Sea-Glass Charm, and the silver gull-whistle; the Grand Sea-Serpent Float and the clockwork gulls; all stat blocks in File 2.

Combat Tracker — The Tide Festival

Two real fights. Encounter 1 is **avoidable** — the Brack Brothers can be bought off, bluffed, or scared away — but if it comes to blows they fight to win. Encounter 2 is the session's big set piece: an animated parade float with a crowd to save, three ways to stop it, and Lord Gullwhistle making his last try for the ledger. **Normal rules apply:** a PC who drops to 0 HP makes death saves. Villains dropped by melee can be knocked out instead of killed, as usual.

Party: four PCs at Level 6. 2014 DMG per-PC thresholds — **Easy 300 · Medium 600 · Hard 900 · Deadly 1,400** — so at **4 PCs**: **Easy 1,200 · Medium 2,400 · Hard 3,600 · Deadly 5,600.** Every stat block is † **homebrew** except Clacker (a *Monster Manual* giant crab); CRs are provisional budget ratings.

> ***Tactical maps are generated.*** *The written distances and terrain below remain authoritative if the artwork differs. Exact prompts are in* `images/images.json`.

Encounter 1 — The Brack Brothers' Roadblock

Act I, Scene 1.1 · Avoidable · Medium (1,375 XP × 2 = 2,750 adjusted / Medium 2,400 – Hard 3,600 at 4×L6)

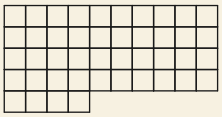
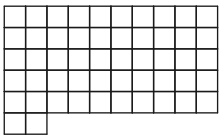
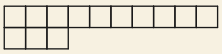
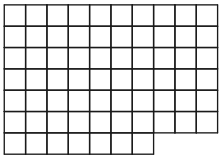
Summary

Location	The salt road, about six miles east of the Sarshel Light, two hours after sunrise. An old salt-collector's hut ringed with salvage, a striped gate pole, salt barrels, an upturned rowboat, a broken mast hung with salvage rigging, and Clacker's brine tub.
Light	Bright morning sun.
Terrain	Flat salt flat; a 15-ft road; a patch of **wet salt mud** (difficult terrain); props anyone can use (see *Triggers*).
Antagonists	**Mort Brack**, **Ned Brack**, **Ollie Brack** (CR 2 provisional each, †) + **Clacker** (giant crab, CR 1/8)
Party	**4 PCs at L6** — Naan, Nalith, Kto, Yinu.
XP	450 × 3 + 25 = 1,375 × **2** (four creatures) = **2,750** → **Medium.**
Duration	3–4 rounds.
Goal (PCs)	Get the walkers past — by any means.
Goal (Bracks)	Take every book and paper from the lighthouse folk, and turn them back into the salt.
Avoid it	Hand over the ledger; **buy them off** (Persuasion DC 13 with 50+ gp, automatic at 100 gp); **bluff** with decoy papers (Deception DC 14); or **scare them off** (Intimidation DC 15, advantage after a show of real power). See File 1, Scene 1.1.
Morale	They surrender when **Mort drops** or **two brothers are at 0 HP**. With Mort down and the road open, Ned runs; Ollie stays with his fallen brothers.

Round Strip & Initiative

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6

NPC initiative is pre-rolled (`round(avg(1d20 + DEX))`). PCs roll live and write into the blank rows.

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
__	_____	__	_____	_____
14	Ned Brack	14	**44** 	☐
13	Mort Brack	15	**52** 	☐
13	Clacker	15	**13** 	Tub at half HP
__	_____	__	_____	_____
__	_____	__	_____	_____
10	Ollie Brack	13	**67** 	**Grappling** ☐
__	_____	__	_____	_____

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

- **Opening.** Mort talks first. Unless the party attacks or one of the *Avoid it* options lands, Ned opens from behind the rowboat and Ollie comes round the barrels. The walkers pull back 60 ft to Dagna's wagon and stay out of the fight.
- **Surrender.** When **Mort drops** or **two brothers are at 0 HP**, the rest throw down their weapons: *"Enough! Enough. You've made your point."* They trade information for their lives (the gent's description and the "G." note).
- **The gate pole.** Anyone next to the hut can drop the striped pole as a bonus action: one creature on the road beside the hut makes a **DC 12 Dex save** or falls prone.
- **Salt barrels.** Anyone next to the barrel stack can tip one as an action: a 15-ft line of rolling barrel, **DC 12 Dex save** or **1d6 bludgeoning** and prone.
- **The salvage rigging.** A creature next to the mast can swing up to 20 ft on the hanging ropes as part of its move without provoking opportunity attacks (**Acrobatics DC 10**, or land prone at the end).
- **The hut.** Full cover inside. Any single hit of 10+ bludgeoning or force damage on the hut knocks a wall flat; whoever is inside is now in the open.

- **The walkers.** If a Brack moves toward the wagon, call it out first. Oren and Dagna will put themselves between him and the children; give the party a turn to answer before anything happens to them.

Tactics Summary

- **Mort Brack** — R1: throws the **Weighted Net** at the most dangerous-looking caster, then calls targets for his brothers. R2+: cudgels whoever is netted or prone, and **Parries** the biggest hit. Surrenders for everyone when it's clearly lost.
- **Ned Brack** — Stays behind the rowboat, slings at casters and archers, and scatters **caltrops** in the path of anyone charging him.
- **Ollie Brack** — Charges the nearest melee PC, grapples, and throws them into the mud or the barrels. Goes straight for anyone who drops a brother (*Brother's Keeper*).
- **Clacker** — Grapples whoever Ollie is fighting; retreats to the tub at half HP.

Loot / Aftermath

- **Mort's purse: 25 gp** — Gullwhistle's down payment.
- **The "G." note** in Mort's coat (see File 1, Scene 1.1).
- **Salvage** around the hut: rope, tar, ship's brass, and a good spyglass (worth 25 gp in the city, if the party wants it).
- **What happens to the Bracks:** see File 1, Scene 1.1 *Conditional follow-through*.

Mort Brack

> *Lean and sharp-featured, black moustache, long weathered grey coat, a weighted net over one shoulder. Polite, and never means it.*

Medium humanoid (human), Neutral Evil, † homebrew · CR 2 provisional (450 XP)

AC	15 (studded leather)
HP	**52** (8d8 + 16) · **Bloodied 26**
Speed	30 ft.
STR / DEX / CON	14 (+2) · 14 (+2) · 14 (+2)
INT / WIS / CHA	12 (+1) · 11 (+0) · 15 (+2)
Skills	Deception +4, Intimidation +4, Perception +2
Senses	Passive Perception 12
Languages	Common

Actions. ***Multiattack.*** Two **Cudgel** attacks. ***Cudgel.*** Melee, reach 5 ft., **+4**, **1d8 + 2 bludgeoning**. ***Weighted Net (Recharge 5–6).*** Ranged 15 ft., **+4** against a Large or smaller creature: the target is **restrained** until it or a creature next to it uses an action to make a **DC 12 Strength** check and pulls free, or the net (AC 10, 5 HP) is cut.

Reactions. ***Parry.*** Mort adds 2 to his AC against one melee attack that would hit him, if he can see the attacker.

Ned Brack

> *Wiry and squinting, a leather bandolier of lead shot across his chest, a sling always turning in his hand. Says almost nothing.*

Medium humanoid (human), Neutral Evil, † homebrew · CR 2 provisional (450 XP)

AC	14 (leather)
HP	**44** (8d8 + 8) · **Bloodied 22**
Speed	30 ft.
STR / DEX / CON	10 (+0) · 17 (+3) · 12 (+1)
INT / WIS / CHA	11 (+0) · 13 (+1) · 10 (+0)
Skills	Perception +3, Stealth +5
Senses	Passive Perception 13
Languages	Common

Traits. ***Wrecker's Eye.*** Long range doesn't give Ned disadvantage, and his sling attacks ignore half cover.

Actions. ***Multiattack.*** Two **Lead-Shot Sling** attacks. ***Lead-Shot Sling.*** Ranged 30/120 ft., **+5**, **1d6 + 3 bludgeoning**.

Bonus Actions. ***Caltrop Scatter (once per fight).*** Ned throws a bag of caltrops to cover a 10-ft. square within 20 ft. A creature that enters the area makes a **DC 13 Dex save** or stops moving and takes **1 piercing damage**, and its speed drops by 10 ft. until it regains at least 1 HP.

Ollie Brack

> *Huge and bald, scarred knuckles wrapped in cloth. Quiet, devoted to his brothers, and very strong.*

Medium humanoid (human), Neutral, † homebrew · CR 2 provisional (450 XP)

AC	13 (hide)
HP	**67** (9d8 + 27) · **Bloodied 33**
Speed	30 ft.
STR / DEX / CON	18 (+4) · 9 (–1) · 16 (+3)
INT / WIS / CHA	8 (–1) · 10 (+0) · 9 (–1)
Skills	Athletics +6
Senses	Passive Perception 10
Languages	Common

Traits. ***Brother's Keeper.*** When a creature Ollie can see drops one of his brothers to 0 HP, Ollie can use his reaction to move up to his speed toward that creature.

Actions. ***Multiattack.*** Two **Fist** attacks; he can replace one with **Grab**. ***Fist.*** Melee, reach 5 ft., **+6**, **1d8 + 4 bludgeoning**. ***Grab.*** Melee, reach 5 ft., **+6**: the target is **grappled** (escape DC 14). He can grapple one creature at a time. ***Throw.*** Ollie throws a Medium or smaller creature he is grappling up to 15 ft.: it takes **2d6 + 4 bludgeoning** and lands prone.

Clacker (Giant Crab)

> *A big red crab in a battered rope harness. The Bracks use it to drag salvage off the wrecks.*

Medium beast, unaligned · CR 1/8 (25 XP) — *Monster Manual* giant crab.

AC	15 (natural armor)
HP	**13** (3d8) · **Bloodied 6**
Speed	30 ft., swim 30 ft.
STR / DEX / CON	13 (+1) · 15 (+2) · 11 (+0)
INT / WIS / CHA	1 (–5) · 9 (–1) · 3 (–4)
Skills	Stealth +4
Senses	Blindsight 30 ft., Passive Perception 9
Languages	—

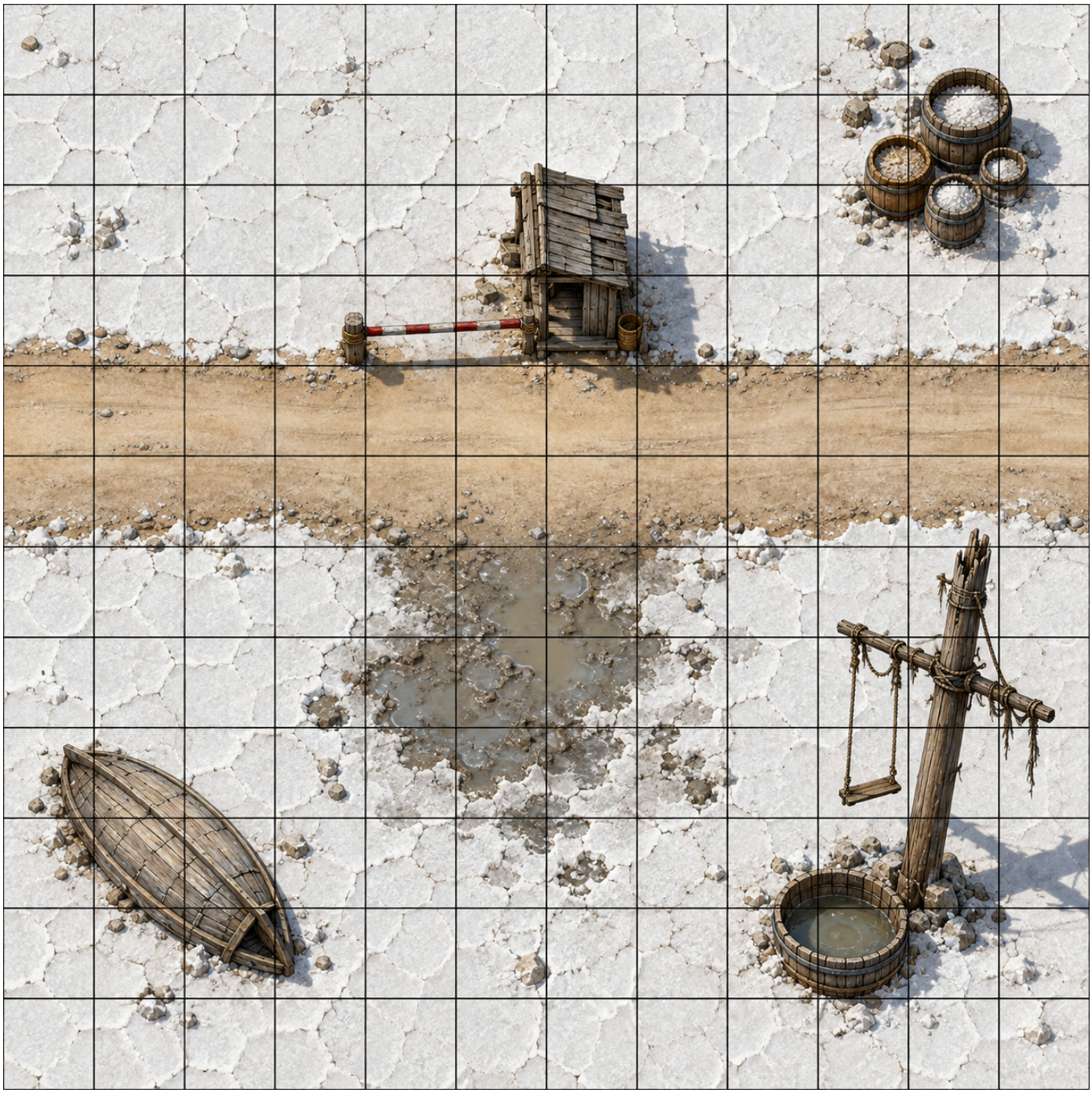
Traits. ***Amphibious.*** Breathes air and water.

Actions. ***Claw.*** Melee, reach 5 ft., **+3**, **1d6 + 1 bludgeoning**, and the target is **grappled** (escape DC 11). It has two claws, each able to grapple one target.

Encounter 1 — Tactical Layout *(written dimensions remain authoritative)*

Grid: 1 square = 5 ft. Field is 60 ft. × 60 ft. (12 × 12 squares), north up. The party and the walkers come in from the **west edge** on the road; the walkers pull back 60 ft., off the map.

- **The road** runs west to east across the middle of the field, **15 ft. wide**, from 25 ft. to 40 ft. south of the north edge.
- **The hut** — **10 × 10 ft.**, just north of the road at the field's centre. Full cover inside. Mort starts at the gate pole beside it.
- **The gate pole** lies across the road on the hut's east side.
- **Salt barrels** — a **10 × 10 ft.** stack in the north-east corner area. Half cover. Ollie starts behind them (Perception DC 13 to spot).
- **Upturned rowboat** — **10 × 5 ft.**, south-west of the road. Half cover (which Ned's own shots ignore). Ned starts behind it.
- **Broken mast and salvage rigging** — south-east of the road; **Clacker's brine tub** sits beside it.
- **Wet salt mud** — a **15 × 15 ft.** patch just south of the road, centre field. Difficult terrain.
- **Distances:** west edge → hut **25 ft.**; hut → barrels **20 ft.**; hut → rowboat **30 ft.**; hut → mast **25 ft.**



Encounter 2 — The Grand Sea-Serpent Float

Act III, Scene 3.1 · Hard (2,450 XP × 2 = 4,900 adjusted / Hard 3,600 – Deadly 5,600 at 4×L6)

Summary

Location	**Harbor Way** at sunset — a 30-ft-wide festival street running south to the harbor plaza and its big round fountain. Grandstands, a pickle stall, a puppet show, two confetti cannons.
Light	Bright — sunset plus lanterns everywhere.
Terrain	Cobbles; the **fountain** (20 ft. across, 2 ft. deep: difficult terrain); confetti and lantern paper everywhere.
Antagonists	**Lord Percival Gullwhistle** (CR 2 provisional, †) + 1× **Grand Sea-Serpent Float** (CR 5 provisional, †) + 2× **Clockwork Gull** (CR 1/2 provisional, †)
Bystanders	Three **crowd groups** in the float's path: **A — the grandstand**, **B — the pickle stall**, **C — the puppet show** (little kids).
Party	**4 PCs at L6** — Naan, Nalith, Kto, Yinu.
XP	1,800 + 450 + 100 × 2 = 2,450 × **2** (four creatures) = **4,900** → **Hard.**
Duration	4–5 rounds.
Goal (PCs)	Stop the float, save the crowd, keep the ledger, and catch Gullwhistle.
Goal (Gullwhistle)	Get the ledger (the gulls snatch it); failing that, escape to his rowboat off the south edge.
Three ways to stop the float	**(1)** Reduce it to 0 HP. **(2)** ***Dispel Magic*** (see *Triggers*). **(3)** Climb aboard and turn the **brass wind-key** twice.
Where Gullwhistle starts	**Not exposed:** front row of the grandstand (Crowd A), reading the scroll quietly. **Exposed:** riding the float's back.

Round Strip & Initiative

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8

NPC initiative is pre-rolled (`round(avg(1d20 + DEX))`). PCs roll live and write into the blank rows.

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
__	_____	__	_____	_____
14	Lord Gullwhistle	15	**52** ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐	☐☐
__	_____	__	_____	_____
13	Clockwork Gull A	13	**22** ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐	Carrying: _____
13	Clockwork Gull B	13	**22** ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐	Carrying: _____
__	_____	__	_____	_____
__	_____	__	_____	_____
10	Grand Sea-Serpent Float	15	**136 — cross off each 10 lost** ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐

Crowd groups: A — grandstand [ ] saved [ ] scattered · B — pickle stall [ ] saved [ ] scattered · C — puppet show [ ] saved [ ] scattered

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

- **Before initiative — who has the ledger?** Ask the table which PC is carrying it (or whether it was left with Plumm or Amsel). If nobody has it, the gulls attack PCs instead.
- **Round 1 — Waking Up.** Gullwhistle reads the scroll on his first turn (it crumbles to glowing ash). On its first turn the float only grinds, shudders, and hisses steam: **it does not move.** Every PC gets a turn to react before it rolls.
- **Runaway.** From round 2, at the start of each of its turns the float rolls up to 30 ft. toward the **nearest crowd group not yet saved or scattered**. **Distracted:** if any creature hit it since its last turn, it rolls toward the creature that hit it most recently instead, and attacks that creature. Hitting it is how you pull it away from the crowd. When no crowd groups are left, it chases whoever hit it last.
- **Crowd groups.** A PC within 10 ft. of a group can use an action to get them clear — shouting, herding, carrying kids, a clever spell. No roll for a sensible plan; DC 10 for a wild one. Mark it **saved**. If the float reaches a group that hasn't been saved, that group **scatters**: stalls smashed and several people hurt (nobody dies; the Hall's healers see to them overnight). It isn't saved.
- **Dispel Magic.** The *Scroll of the Rising Tide* † is a **5th-level** effect: ***dispel magic*** cast with a 5th-level slot ends it automatically; with a lower slot, make a spellcasting ability check, **DC 15**. When it ends, the float rolls down into the fountain and stops.

- **The brass wind-key.** A creature next to the float can climb aboard as part of its move (**Athletics or Acrobatics DC 13**, costs 10 ft.; automatic for the first PC to try **if Marisol shouted the secret** in round 1). Aboard, it moves with the float; Chomp can't reach it, but Tail Swipe can — on a hit, the rider is also thrown 10 ft. off the float and lands prone. Turning the key is an action with a **DC 13 Strength (Athletics)** check; **two successes** wind it down and it rolls into the fountain.
- **The ledger.** A clockwork gull can use **Snatch** on the carrier (DC 12 Dex save). A gull carrying the ledger flies toward Gullwhistle; if it ends its turn within 5 ft. of him, he takes it (no action). A gull that takes any damage while carrying it drops it in its space.
- **Gullwhistle's escape.** His rowboat waits at the quay steps just beyond the **south edge** of the harbor plaza. If he leaves the map by the south edge, he is gone. Telegraph it: anyone looking south sees an oarsman waiting with his oars up.
- **Gullwhistle's surrender.** At **15 HP or fewer** with no way out (charm spent, path south blocked), he yields and demands the Council.
- **Area spells near crowds.** Before anyone casts *fireball*, *lightning bolt*, or another area spell, warn the table if the area touches an unsaved crowd group. If they cast anyway, the crowd is caught: those people are hurt, and the group counts as **scattered**.
- **Hazards anyone can use:** a **confetti cannon** (action, adjacent PC: 30-ft. line, **DC 13 Con save** or blinded until the end of the target's next turn — works on the float, the gulls, and Gullwhistle); a **fountain water jet** (action, adjacent PC: 30-ft. line, **DC 13 Str save** or pushed 10 ft. and prone — the Huge float is only pushed, never knocked prone); **pickle barrels** at stall B (action: 15-ft. line, **DC 12 Dex save** or **1d6 bludgeoning** and prone).
- **Allies who may arrive:** the **Brack Brothers** (if they went free in 1.1) clear one crowd group on round 2; **Lady Marisol** (if she switched sides in 2.2) shouts the wind-key secret on round 1.
- **When the float stops:** it ends in the fountain with a long dying whistle of steam. The gulls drop out of the sky and lie on the cobbles, ticking. If Gullwhistle is still free, he runs for the boat. Go to Scene 3.2 once he is taken or gone.

Tactics Summary

- **Lord Gullwhistle** — R1: reads the scroll. R2+: **whistles** a gull at the ledger carrier and works his way south toward the quay. Fights with his rapier only when cornered; uses the **Sea-Glass Charm** to break away when a PC blocks him. **Parries** the first big hit each round.
- **Grand Sea-Serpent Float** — R1: wakes up (no move). R2+: Runaway toward the nearest unsaved crowd, Chomp whatever is in front of it, Tail Swipe anyone behind or beside it. Uses **Steam Breath** whenever it recharges and three or more creatures are in the cone.
- **Clockwork Gulls** — **Snatch** at the ledger carrier and fly it to Gullwhistle; otherwise dive-bomb whoever is hurting him.

Loot / Aftermath

- **On Gullwhistle** (if taken): Veyra's letter, the scroll's ash, the Sea-Glass Charm (spent; a pretty bauble now), his **gold gull pin**, his rapier, and the ledger if the gulls brought it to him.
- **The float's wreck**: brass gears, painted canvas, and a great grinning wooden head the festival keeps as a reminder.
- **Rewards** come in Scene 3.2 (justice, the crowd's cheers, Heroic Inspiration if all three groups were saved) — see File 1 *Loot & Rewards Summary*.

Lord Percival Gullwhistle

> *Slim and elegant, silver-streaked ginger beard, teal-and-gold frock coat, a gull feather in his tricorn, a gold gull pin, a rapier he knows how to use. Gracious to the very end.*

Medium humanoid (human), Neutral Evil, † homebrew · CR 2 provisional (450 XP)

AC	15 (fine brigandine under his coat)
HP	**52** (8d8 + 16) · **Bloodied 26**
Speed	30 ft.
STR / DEX / CON	10 (+0) · 16 (+3) · 14 (+2)
INT / WIS / CHA	14 (+2) · 12 (+1) · 17 (+3)
Saving Throws	Dex +5, Wis +3
Skills	Deception +7, Insight +3, Persuasion +7
Senses	Passive Perception 11
Languages	Common, Elvish

Actions. ***Multiattack.*** Two **Rapier** attacks. ***Rapier.*** Melee, reach 5 ft., **+5**, **1d8 + 3 piercing**.

Bonus Actions. ***Silver Gull-Whistle.*** One clockwork gull within 60 ft. that can hear him uses its reaction to fly up to 25 ft. and make one Peck or Snatch. ***Sea-Glass Charm (once).*** In a swirl of salt mist, Gullwhistle teleports up to 30 ft. to an unoccupied space he can see.

Reactions. ***Parry.*** Gullwhistle adds 2 to his AC against one melee attack that would hit him, if he can see the attacker.

Grand Sea-Serpent Float

> *A house-sized clockwork sea serpent of painted wood, canvas, and brass gears, teal-and-gold scales, its painted grin split open into rows of brass teeth, glass eyes glowing sea-green, steam hissing from its jaws, and a big brass wind-key on its back.*

Huge construct, unaligned, † homebrew · CR 5 provisional (1,800 XP)

AC	15 (painted planks)
HP	**136** (13d12 + 52) · **Bloodied 68**
Speed	30 ft. (wheels; it cannot climb)
STR / DEX / CON	20 (+5) · 8 (–1) · 18 (+4)
INT / WIS / CHA	3 (–4) · 10 (+0) · 1 (–5)
Damage Immunities	Poison, psychic
Condition Immunities	Charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned
Senses	Darkvision 60 ft. (glass eyes), Passive Perception 10
Languages	—

Traits. ***Animated by the Scroll.*** A 5th-level magical effect; see *Dispel Magic* in Triggers. ***Runaway / Distracted / Waking Up.*** See Triggers. ***Brass Wind-Key.*** Two successful DC 13 Strength (Athletics) actions by a creature aboard stop it.

Actions. ***Multiattack.*** One **Chomp** and one **Tail Swipe**. ***Chomp.*** Melee, reach 10 ft., **+7**, **3d8 + 5 piercing**. ***Tail Swipe.*** Melee, reach 15 ft., **+7**, **2d8 + 5 bludgeoning**, and the target makes a **DC 15 Str save** or falls prone. ***Steam Breath (Recharge 5–6).*** Replaces Multiattack. A 30-ft. cone of scalding steam: each creature in it makes a **DC 14 Dex save**, taking **4d6 fire damage** on a failed save, or half as much on a success.

On 0 HP. It collapses into the fountain in a heap of canvas, springs, and steam.

Clockwork Gull

> *A brass seagull the size of a cat, the Gull Club's mascot, flapping on wind-up wings. It turns its head whenever the silver whistle blows.*

Small construct, unaligned, † homebrew · CR 1/2 provisional (100 XP)

AC	13
HP	**22** (5d6 + 5) · **Bloodied 11**
Speed	10 ft., fly 50 ft.
STR / DEX / CON	8 (–1) · 14 (+2) · 12 (+1)
INT / WIS / CHA	3 (–4) · 10 (+0) · 5 (–3)
Damage Immunities	Poison
Condition Immunities	Poisoned
Senses	Passive Perception 10
Languages	—

Traits. ***Flyby.*** Doesn't provoke opportunity attacks when it flies out of an enemy's reach. ***Dive-Bomb.*** If it flies at least 20 ft. straight toward a target and then hits it with Peck, the target makes a **DC 12 Str save** or falls prone.

Actions. ***Peck.*** Melee, reach 5 ft., **+4**, **1d6 + 2 piercing**.

Bonus Actions. ***Snatch.*** One creature within 5 ft. carrying a small object the gull is after (the ledger, if Gullwhistle has whistled for it) makes a **DC 12 Dex save** or the gull takes it. It can't take a weapon or a spellcasting focus that is being held.

On 0 HP. Drops out of the air and lies on the cobbles, ticking. Anything it carried falls in its space.

Encounter 2 — Tactical Layout *(written dimensions remain authoritative)*

Grid: 1 square = 5 ft. Field is 80 ft. × 80 ft. (16 × 16 squares), north up. The float starts at the north edge; the party is at the front of the parade, about **30 ft. south of the float**, in the middle of the street.

- **Harbor Way** — a **30-ft.-wide** cobbled street running north to south down the middle of the field.
- **The float** starts at the **north edge, centred on the street** (Huge, 15 × 15 ft.). If the club was exposed, Gullwhistle is on its back.
- **Crowd A — the grandstand** — wooden bleachers **15 × 30 ft.** on the street's **west** side, starting 15 ft. from the north edge. If the club wasn't exposed, Gullwhistle starts in its front row.
- **Crowd B — the pickle stall** — a stall and a parked cart, **15 × 15 ft.**, on the street's **east** side, starting 25 ft. from the north edge. Dagna's barrels are here.
- **Crowd C — the puppet show** — a striped booth, **10 × 10 ft.**, **south-west**, beside the fountain.
- **The harbor plaza** fills the **southern 20 ft.** of the field; the **fountain** is **20 ft. across**, centred in the plaza. **The quay steps and Gullwhistle's rowboat** are just beyond the south edge.
- **Confetti cannons** — one at each **north corner** of the street.
- **Distances:** float → party **30 ft.**; float → grandstand **~15 ft.**; float → pickle stall **~25 ft.**; float → puppet show **~45 ft.**; float → fountain **~45 ft.**; grandstand front row → south edge **~50 ft.**



Player Handouts — The Tide Festival

Session 008 · Show each picture at the table when the party meets that person or place — not all at once, and not before.

> ***Portrait pages are image and name only.*** *Each portrait page holds one picture scaled to fill the sheet and the name in large bold type at the foot of the page, added by the PDF renderer. The artwork has no lettering of its own. Read the cues from File 1 aloud.*

Where We Left Off



Last session (007): Oberon's portal dropped you at night on the dried-up bed of the Sea of Fallen Stars, where a lighthouse with no sea to warn swept its beam over you, and each of you saw the thing you wanted most — and believed it was waiting inside the tower. At the stranded ship *Embergull*, the camp keeper Oren fed you soup and warned you that the light eats people. **Yinu** tried to fly to the tower and **vanished in the beam** — and woke up **chained in the lantern room** with four other prisoners, then Misty Stepped free. At the door, **Nalith** broke the keeper **Tamsin Reed**'s spell with *dispel magic*, and Tamsin led you to the top.

In the lantern room, a woman named **Veyra** was calling up a **Brine Fiend** to eat the prisoners. **Kto**'s arrows, **Naan**'s *cloud of daggers*, and Yinu's shadowspawn wore them down, and **Yinu's lightning bolt** finished Veyra — the demon fell apart into a puddle of salt water. Tamsin turned her key and **the light went out**. You freed the four prisoners and found Veyra's **ledger**: a list of people in the city of **New Sarshel** who paid her for her work.

Today: the sun is coming up, the lighthouse is dark behind you, and about fifteen grateful people are walking with you nine miles east to New Sarshel.

New Sarshel at the Tide Festival



- A harbor city of pale stone towers and red roofs that **chased the sea**: when the water drew back, New Sarshel built new docks to follow it, and grew rich.
- Every balcony has a paper lantern. Every street has bunting. Somebody is always playing a fiddle.
- It is the **Tide Festival**, and everyone already seems to know who you are.



Tamsin Reed



The Brack Brothers



Lord Percival Gullwhistle



Tibbet Sparkwright

The Grand Sea-Serpent Float



- A house-sized clockwork sea serpent of painted wood and brass gears, teal and gold — and its painted grin has split open into rows of brass teeth.
- Steam hissing from its jaws. Glass eyes glowing sea-green. The band stops mid-note, and the crowd starts to run.

Handout — The Tide Festival Schedule

(Warden Plumm hands this out at the gate in Scene 1.2.)

THE TIDE FESTIVAL OF NEW SARSHEL — *the city that caught the sea!*

Lantern Eve

All day — stalls open on Festival Green

Dusk — **Harbor Lanterns**: float a lantern for someone you miss or something you hope for

Tide Day

Noon — **The Noon Bells** and the Blessing of the Tide at the Hall of Many Lights

Afternoon — **Festival Games** on Festival Green: the Archery Contest · the Crab Races · the Pickle-Eating Contest (*no pickled eggs this year, by request*)

Sunset — **The Grand Parade** down Harbor Way to the fountain, featuring the Gilded Gull Club's famous Sea-Serpent Float

Nightfall — **Fireworks** over the harbor by Tibbet Sparkwright

Heroes of the lighthouse ride at the front of the parade, free!

Handout — Veyra's Ledger

(The party already has this. Read or show it whenever they look at it.)

A small leather book in a neat hand. Most pages are notes in a fiery script you can't read. One page is a list:

- **Lord Percival Gullwhistle** — 400 gp — *for the Summoning*
- **Lady Marisol Brightwater** — 400 gp — *for the Summoning*
- **Sir Dunstan Pellow** — 400 gp — *for the Summoning*

Under the list, underlined twice: *"G.G.C. — pay on the full moon."*

DM Quick Reference — The Tide Festival

Party and continuity

- **4 PCs at Level 6:** Naan (Lilli), Nalith (Piper), Kto (Kaitlyn), Yinu (Sev). Not playing: Fiorn (Fox — own game), Dirk (Ari), Tyvlex (Kaila).
- **Thresholds (4×L6):** Easy 1,200 · Medium 2,400 · Hard 3,600 · Deadly 5,600.
- **Starts:** straight after Session 007 — dawn on the salt road, lighthouse dark, ledger in hand, ~15 walkers.
- **Rest:** short rest on the road (breakfast); **long rest Lantern Eve night** at the Salty Pelican.
- **Tone:** upbeat day, real villains. Gullwhistle and the Bracks play it straight; the lightness comes from the walkers, Plumm, Amsel, Tibbet, Lorrow, and the games. Normal death saves; bystanders can be hurt, nobody dies on screen.

Act / Scene Flow

ID	Scene	Encounter	Key cues	Leads to
1.1	The Salt Road	**Enc. 1** (avoidable, Medium)	Walkers' personalities; wreckers' roadblock; hand over / buy off / bluff / scare / fight; Mort's **gull purse** (always); if they talk, **"golden bird pin, gull feather"** + the **"G." note**	1.2
1.2	Heroes at the Gate	None	Wren ran ahead → crowd cheers; Warden Plumm (Gullwhistle is on her committee); free beds; schedule handout; Lantern Eve lanterns (Nalith); long rest	2.1
2.1	Bells and Blessings	None	Noon Bells; mass for the PC who missed it (most likely Naan); Kto's name read out; Amsel reads ledger → **Gilded Gull Club, Gull Row, "one of them knew"**	2.2
2.2	Festival Games and the Gilded Gulls	None	Archery (Kto) · crabs (Nalith) · fireworks (Yinu) · pickles (all); Gullwhistle's offer then threat; Marisol switches; Dunstan cracks; Tibbet: **"the book goes into the harbor with them"**	3.1
3.1	The Serpent Wakes	**Enc. 2** (Hard)	Scroll read; save 3 crowd groups; stop the float 3 ways; gulls go for the ledger; Gullwhistle runs for the quay	3.2
3.2	Fireworks and Justice	None	Gullwhistle to the Council (or escaped); estate seized → survivors' homes; Marisol's feast; Heroes of the Tide; Tamsin keeps the harbor light; Captain Lorrow's offer	Session 009

The secret (DM only)

- The **Gilded Gull Club** (Gullwhistle, Brightwater, Pellow) paid Veyra **400 gp each** to "summon the tide" back to **Gull Row**, now a mile inland. The price included "feeding the light": travellers lured off the salt road.
- **Gullwhistle knew** and agreed. **Marisol** was fooled. **Dunstan** suspected and chose not to ask.
- Gullwhistle saw the light go out, hired the **Bracks**, and carries Veyra's ***Scroll of the Rising Tide*** (really an animate-objects scroll) and her letter: *"The light will need feeding until the tide turns. You agreed the price. — V."*

Conditions that carry forward

- **Bracks bought off / scared off / bluffed / let go (1.1)** → they clear one crowd group on round 2 of Enc. 2.
- **Bracks taken in (1.1)** → in the stocks on Festival Green in 2.2; Mort shouts *"Oi! G! You owe us fifty!"* at Gullwhistle.
- **Bracks fled (1.1)** → gone.
- **Ledger handed to the Bracks (1.1)** → Amsel names the club from the gull purse; ledger is in Gullwhistle's coat in 3.1; gulls attack PCs instead.
- **Ledger or note shown to Plumm (1.2)** → in 2.2 she points out the three Gulls by name.
- **Decoy fooled the Bracks (1.1)** → Gullwhistle knows by 2.2, and is colder.
- **Club exposed (2.2)** → Gullwhistle rides the float's back and reads openly. **Not exposed** → he reads quietly from the grandstand. **3.1 happens either way.**
- **Marisol switched sides (2.2)** → she shouts the wind-key secret on round 1; first climb aboard is automatic.
- **Scroll and letter lifted (2.2)** → the letter is proof; he reads a second copy from the grandstand.
- **Crowd groups saved (3.1)** → bigger cheers; **all three saved = Heroic Inspiration for every PC**.
- **Gullwhistle taken (3.1)** → Council, estate seized, gold gull pin trophy. **Escaped** → wanted man; leave it open.

Encounter 1 — Brack Brothers (Act I, Scene 1.1)

- **Mort** AC 15, HP 52, net · **Ned** AC 14, HP 44, sling + caltrops · **Ollie** AC 13, HP 67, grab + throw · **Clacker** AC 15, HP 13.
- **Avoid:** hand over the ledger; buy off (Persuasion DC 13 with 50+ gp); decoy (Deception DC 14); scare (Intimidation DC 15).
- **Surrender:** Mort drops, or two brothers at 0 HP.
- **Props:** gate pole (DC 12 Dex), salt barrels (DC 12 Dex, 1d6), rigging swing (Acrobatics DC 10), flimsy hut.
- **Normal rules:** PCs make death saves.

Encounter 2 — The Float (Act III, Scene 3.1)

- **Float** AC 15, HP 136, speed 30 · Chomp +7 (3d8+5) · Tail +7 reach 15 (2d8+5, DC 15 Str or prone) · Steam Breath (DC 14 Dex, 4d6 fire, half on save).
- **Gullwhistle** AC 15, HP 52 · Rapier ×2 +5 (1d8+3) · Gull-Whistle · Sea-Glass Charm (teleport 30 ft., once) · Parry.

- **Gulls ×2** AC 13, HP 22, fly 50 · Peck +4 (1d6+2) · Snatch the ledger (DC 12 Dex).
- **Round 1:** scroll read; float wakes, doesn't move.
- **Runaway:** rolls at the nearest unsaved crowd; **hit it and it chases you instead.**
- **Save a crowd:** action within 10 ft., no roll for a sensible plan.
- **Stop it:** 0 HP · *dispel magic* (5th-level effect; DC 15 check below 5th) · wind-key: climb DC 13, then two DC 13 Athletics actions.
- **Gullwhistle escapes** off the south edge (rowboat); **surrenders** at 15 HP or fewer with no way out.

NPC cues

NPC	Voice / look	Wants	Gives
Wren Ashby	Breathless, autograph book	To meet heroes	Runs ahead → heroes' welcome
Hettie Quillfeather	Halfling, ink-stained, map	Show off her map	Gull Row is a mile inland — the "why"
Dagna Stoutbarrel	Dwarf, pickle wagon	Win the pickle contest	Pickle contest; barrels in Enc. 2
Bram Tolliver	Old singer	Sing	A shanty at every "sea"
Mort Brack	Polite, never means it	His fifty gold	The pin clue and the "G." note
Warden Plumm	Halfling, clipboard, whistle	A perfect festival	Beds, schedule, the watch, titles
Brother Amsel	Round, kind, nosy	Justice for the light's victims	Mass; reads the ledger; letter home
Gullwhistle	Gracious, cold eyes	The ledger gone; his name clean	An offer, then a threat; the scroll
Marisol Brightwater	Polite, sad, nervous	Swim off her pier; be good	Confession; wind-key secret; feast
Dunstan Pellow	Bluster, cane, scared	Never be blamed	"Percival said the light needed feeding!"
Tibbet Sparkwright	Old gnome, singed, loud	Perfect finale	The overheard threat; *Pyrotechnics* scroll
Tamsin Reed	Tired, warm	Something to keep	Yinu's staff; new keeper of the harbor light
Captain Ama Lorrow	Half-orc, grin, bad jokes	Good company	Free passage → Session 009

Rewards

- 25 gp and the "G." note (Bracks) · 600 gp (seized estate and Marisol) · 2 potions of healing (Hall) · 3 +1 arrows and sash (archery) · Admiral Snips (crabs) · scroll of *Pyrotechnics* (Tibbet) · Golden Gherkin (pickles) · Gullwhistle's gold gull pin (if taken) · Heroic Inspiration (all crowds saved) · free passage (*Laughing Otter*).

Leave open

- Veyra's real master and purpose · Gullwhistle, if he escaped · Sela, Oberon · drow under Old Skull · Yinu's cipher book · Naan's Lathander letter · where Fiorn is.

Post-play notes

- Where does the party want the *Laughing Otter* to take them? → Session 009.
- Who won which game? Who kept the ledger? Was Gullwhistle taken or did he escape?